

E-mail clients: which one's for me?

Before e-mail software, checking e-mail wasn't a simple mouse click away. Back then, TELNET was the only way to go. It was text-based, slow and generally not so easy to use since everything, right from logging in, had to be done manually. Can you imagine having to connect, login and use a complicated menu system just to check your mail?

With today's software, all that mundane work is completely automated but it doesn't just stop there. Reviewed here are five mail clients that go beyond just sending and receiving your messages. Spice up your experience with some feature-packed software. After all, electronic mail is only as good as you make it.

Whether its support for multiple users that you need or just a slicker interface, one of these packages will suit your needs.

Eudora Mail 5.1

Eudora is light, fast, and full of features, but you need to pay \$39.95 to get the



ad-free version. This e-mail client has support for almost all security protocols, it's the perfect companion for PGP, and in general, a highly usable interface makes it an ideal choice for any power user.

Eudora possesses some robust features such as auto redirecting mails, a plethora of filter options at multiple levels, etc. It supports opening multiple windows. You can define your own set of filters for the received mail and if you have shared a folder or mails with another user, then there are a set of predefined filters which can be automatically applied for scanning attachments. This can be helpful while sorting mail for multiple users, and then sharing it over the network. The PureVoice plugin in Eudora allows you to send a voice message as an attachment which can be opened using the PureVoice plug-in on the other side.

Eudora's functional interface is extremely customisable, though it might confuse first time users, as it takes some time to get used to all the features it supports.

Though Eudora has support for multiple user profiles, it is not as simple to make use of this facility. To have multiple user profiles on one computer, you will have to create shortcuts to the Eudora executable for each user, and map it to his mail folder.

Overall, the most customisable and feature-filled of all mail clients, Eudora fits the bill for almost all users because of its ease in usability and multiple versions.

+ Support for voice e-mail

+ Allows multiple folder view in a single window

- Expensive

- Feature rich, but tough to configure for first time users

Price: \$39.95 (approx Rs 1,918)

Web site: www.eudora.com

The Bat! 1.53

The first thing you will notice after configuring this e-mail client is the mail ticker which notifies you every time you receive a mail—you can click on the ticker to read the mail. The Bat! possesses a very good editor which allows you to compose messages which allows you to auto wrap and auto format text. By providing templates, The Bat! simplifies the work of the user to a great extent. On the flip side, this editor does not allow you to create messages in HTML format.



There are default templates for replying, forwarding, and read receipts that can be edited as per the user's need. Apart from the standard set of templates there is something called 'quick templates' in which users can create templates and add macros. This is especially helpful in scripting the replies to similar mails. You can script common replies, adding specific customer information to it using macros, and reverting back quickly.

The Bat! comes with full support for PGP keys and built-in encryption. It doesn't require any other tool like PGPFreeware to be installed. The multiple level sorting and filtering capabilities are commendable too and go far beyond other tools.

The 'parking' feature prevents you from accidentally deleting important messages.

If you want an e-mail client which is not only easy to use but also boasts of powerful filtering, sorting and security capabilities, then this e-mail client is meant for you. However, it is quite expensive for \$36 for a single user business license.

+ Exceptional sorting and filtering capabilities

+ Provides good security features

- Cannot compose messages in HTML format

- Expensive

Price: \$36 (approx Rs 1,728) (business-single user)

Web site: www.rtlabs.com

Common E-mail Error Messages Decoded

There can be a number of reasons that prevent a message from being delivered to the recipient. Here are some of the more common errors that cause a mail to bounce back to you and what they mean.

■ **Lack of disk space:** If a recipient's inbox is full, they will not be able to accommodate further messages stored in their inbox unless some space is freed. Usually, errors such as these remain oblivious to the mail account holder.

Steps to take: In such cases, your local mail server will not attempt to resend

the message at a later time. You will have to send the message again once the user has erased some of their mail.

■ **User or e-mail address unknown:** This is a common problem which tells you that the mail has reached the server correctly, but not the user's mailbox. Either the person's e-mail address is no longer valid or there are some problems at the destination's mail server.

Steps to take: Again, the mail server will not try to send another message automatically. You'll have to resend it.